Concerns about India’s territorial unity and integrity have led India to try and build indigenous military capability instead of simply buying weapons off the shelf, which would make it dependent on other countries. The effort to indigenize weapons manufacturing has not been sufficiently successful to foreclose the option of massive purchases on the global market and India remains one of the world’s top importers of military equipment and arms. Until recently, the Indian government was reluctant to allow even Indian corporations to enter the defence sector and preferred to rely exclusively on public sector enterprises. The private sector has now been invited into the field of defence production because state-owned manufacturers have not reached the production levels of their Chinese counterparts.

The ‘Make in India’ initiative of the Modi government carries forward the legacy of building an Indian defence capacity. The initiative expects that foreign firms will be willing to share their technology in return for access to the Indian market. The assumption is still that the size of the Indian market compensates for bureaucratic hurdles and other inconveniences that serve as a disincentive. The focus still remains on manufacturing locally rather than importing India’s defence needs. In this case, the security imperative has been merged with economic nationalism as a principle of external relations.

INDIAN EXCEPTIONALISM

Many Indians see the role of Indian foreign policy as being a set of measures designed to safeguard Indian nationalism. The desire to find India’s place in the sun, to project India as an example or guide to others, and the belief that as one of the oldest civilizations India was a future great power can all be traced back to the influence of nationalism. The moralistic dimension to India’s foreign policy can also be traced back to the deeply high-minded and value-based independence movement, which was influenced by the views of the leader of the national struggle, Mahatma Gandhi, who is acknowledged as the father of the modern Indian nation.